



RONALDO BOLAÑOS Los Angeles Times

THE CURRENT El Niño, which began forming in June, is shaping up to be the strongest ever experienced, experts say. Above, waves powered by Hurricane Marie slam the Seal Beach Pier on Sunday. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

OIL DEAL SURFACES AS VOTE PROMISE FADES

In Venezuela, fears rise that Trump will leave the unelected leadership in place.

By ANA CEBALLOS AND MERY MOGOLLÓN

WASHINGTON — President Trump has locked in a deal to develop Venezuela's vast oil resources, an arrangement the White House says will bring a country battered by years of economic collapse to a "place where elections are possible."

But the agreement — backed by acting President Delcy Rodríguez, a holdover from the Nicolás Maduro government that Washington deems "illegitimate" — is raising new uncertainty about how entrenched the unelected government may become.

In January, when the U.S. military captured Maduro, Trump did not say how long a democratic transition would take but said Rodríguez was "gracious" and "essentially willing to do what we think is necessary."

Asked by The Times on Wednesday what was stopping him from demanding Venezuela set a firm election date, Trump was blunt: "I just don't think they are ready yet."

"It's very new. We took them out of a dictatorship and we're getting along great with the government," Trump said. But he said an election would happen "soon."

Under the deal, the U.S. government is partnering with an oil producer to create a new company, North American Blue Energy Partners, to develop 17 fields with a proven potential of 65 billion barrels. NABEP will have rights to the fields for 100 years.

For many Venezuelans, the lack of urgency around elections — set against a deal that gives the United

[See Venezuela, A5]

Climate's role seen in bigger El Niño punch

By HAYLEY SMITH

For decades, scientists have struggled to understand the potential link between global warming and El Niño — and whether human activity is making the already powerful climate phenomenon even more extreme and disruptive.

Evidence of a connection has remained elusive, however, as El Niño is notoriously variable, making it difficult to distinguish long-term changes from its natural ebb and flow.

But now — as this year's "super" El Niño gains strength — some researchers say they are getting closer to unraveling the mystery.

A study published recently in the journal *Science* examines temperature data from more than 900 years of coral records from the Galápagos and suggests that El Niños have become much stronger since

people started warming the planet through fossil fuel emissions.

"Prior to the industrial era, we don't see evidence for periods where the El Niño system is as strong as it is in the most recent decades," said Julia Cole, a paleoclimatologist at the University of Michigan and the study's lead author. The swings between warm and cold conditions that define El Niño "were much stronger in the last 40 to 50 years than they were prior to warming."

The research arrives as experts and officials warn that the current El Niño, which began forming in June, is shaping up to be the strongest ever experienced by a considerable margin. It is developing faster than the previous historic super El Niños of 1997-98 and 2015-16, and is already

[See El Niño, A6]



VIVIEN KILLILEA Getty Images

THE MICROSOFT co-founder speaks at a panel bluntly titled "AI, AI, AI."

Bill Gates sounds the alarm on AI at Telluride festival

The tech mogul says the next five years are critical

By JOSH ROTTENBERG

TELLURIDE, Colo. — For four days every Labor Day weekend, the Telluride Film Festival turns this tiny mountain town into something of a refuge from the outside world. Tucked into a box canyon and far from the usual machinery of Hollywood, moviegoers spend their days seeing films they may have known little about

before arriving and talking about them almost nonstop. Artificial intelligence, apparently, did not get the memo.

This year, even Telluride's usually self-contained movie bubble couldn't keep out the existential anxieties surrounding AI. On Saturday, the festival devoted two events to the subject, beginning with "The Humanity Dilemma," an hourlong multimedia

presentation mixing dire warnings with live music and imagery, and continuing with a panel bluntly titled "AI AI AI" featuring Microsoft co-founder Bill Gates.

Introducing "The Humanity Dilemma" at the nearly packed Sheridan Opera House, festival executive director Julie Huntsinger acknowledged that Telluride normally steers clear of taking political sides. "We

[See Telluride, A6]

Trump facing reckoning over economic record

As midterms near, less than a third of voters say he's fulfilled his promises on the issue.

By MICHAEL WILNER AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — A sporadic global trade war led by President Trump is fueling inflation across the U.S. economy, elevating prices on everyday goods, as the war with Iran sends the price of gas on a roller coaster.

Aggressive tax cuts have pushed the national debt past \$40 trillion, driving a growing crisis in the bond market. And an unprecedented immigration crackdown is disrupting the labor supply in agriculture, construction, hospitality and food processing, raising prices even further.

Approaching the halfway point of Trump's second term, a president who won reelection based on a promise to turn the economy around now faces a reckoning in the midterm elections centered largely on his economic record.

Trump's economic agenda has emerged as an increasingly awkward liability

for Republicans heading into the November elections, leaving lawmakers to defend policies that have delivered political pain at home, even as the White House argues they will pay off in the long run.

Polling on Trump's handling of the economy has remained in precariously low territory throughout the summer, entering Labor Day weekend with less than a third of Americans supporting his job performance on their most pressing concerns. One recent poll, from the University of Massachusetts Amherst, found that only 22% perceive the economy in a good or fair state.

And Americans' confidence in the economy is unlikely to improve much ahead of election day, Nov. 3, in part because bad economic news has shown to sink confidence fast. Good news takes much longer to win people back, experts said.

"Voters' opinion of the economy has mostly hardened," said Aaron Klein, chair of economic studies at the Brookings Institution. "People vote the economy of the spring and summer, not November."

Good news has been harder to come by.

[See Trump, A5]

L.A. murder trial a spectator event

Celebrities, content creators line up to see rapper Lil Durk tried in killing-for-hire plot.

By BRITTNY MEJIA

Kyiesha Moncrieffe wanted to experience the heart of Los Angeles. So the tourist visiting from England went to Erewhon, famous for its pricey smoothie once named for Hailey Bieber, a model and celebrity wife.

She went to the Hollywood Walk of Fame, where cosplay characters strutted in the oppressive heat. To Santa Monica beach, where tourists and residents alike sought to cool down in the ocean.

Then, she headed to 1st Street for a look at the clash of justice and celebrity at the murder-for-hire trial of Chicago rapper Durk Banks — better known as Lil Durk.

"I just wanted to come and get the facts of it," said Moncrieffe, who has been following Banks' music "since before he got famous."

It would be hard to find a more L.A. scene than the one playing out downtown in the normally staid Felicitas and Gonzalo Mendez United States Courthouse.

That's where Ye, the rapper formerly known as Kanye West, was warned by a court security officer to lose the dark glasses. Where rapper MGK, best known as Machine Gun Kelly, set off a hand-held metal detector with his chain. Where line sitters were paid to try to secure Banks' own family one of the most desirable seats in town.

But for all the spectacle says about L.A., the issue at the trial's heart is a somber one.

It centers on the killing of 24-year-old Saviya Robinson, who was stopped at a gas station near the bustling Beverly Center on a summer day in 2022. Three shooters unloaded 18 rounds at the black Escalade in which Robinson rode with his cousin and the target — Tyquan Bowman, a rapper known as Quando Rondo.

Both prosecutors and defense attorneys agree that

[See Trial, A8]



JOE RAEDLE Getty Images

PLANE CRASH KILLS 5

An Amazon cargo jet barreled off a runway at Miami International Airport, striking multiple vehicles and bursting into flames. **NATION, A4**

Far-right party poised to win

The Alternative for Germany was projected to secure a strong victory in a regional election. **WORLD, A3**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 92/75. **B5**

Obituaries **B6**
Opinion Voices **A11**

A rock star of women's equality

Gloria Steinem helped generations of women find their own voice. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



He ruffled feathers. His ostriches got shot

By ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

NEWBERRY SPRINGS, Calif. — Two of the ostriches died instantly, hit with .22-caliber slugs fired through the fence of Mike Matson's desert ranch. The third suffered, bleeding out and then collapsing some 40 feet away.

That's the body his wife, Arcelia, found first, one Sunday morning in June.

Matson was angry but wasn't surprised. Months before, a bullet had ended the life of his beloved Pebbles, who left behind a nest with eggs.

Detectives are investigating the two shootings but have made no arrests, according to the San Bernardino County Sheriff's Department.

But Matson believes he knows who is responsible.

A longtime pet breeder, Matson moved to Newberry Springs about nine years ago to raise ostriches and other exotic animals, selling their chicks and eggs. The sun-washed stretch of Mojave Desert sits at the base of a volcanic mountain range roughly 20 miles east of Barstow.

The unincorporated community once was known for its plentiful water supply

— so much so that in 1919, the Santa Fe Railroad renamed the town Water, according to John Wease, a local journalist and history buff.

Shallow groundwater stores supported fruit orchards, alfalfa fields, livestock ranches and, at one point, a water park and dozens of man-made lakes where people could fish, sail and water-ski. A 1968 adver-

[See Ostriches, A7]